So

Deep Research Report

Screen Time and Academic Performance in K-12 Schools

With International Research Perspectives

March 13, 2026

4 Source Categories: Government, News, Academic, Industry
51 Findings Analyzed | 64 Sources (pre-deduplication) | 45 Unique Sources
13 Cross-Referenced Claims | 3 Contradictions Identified | 4 Single-Source Claims

Executive Summary

This deep research report synthesizes 51 findings from 45 unique sources across four distinct categories: government/official sources, news and journalism, peer-reviewed academic research, and industry/practitioner publications. The research examines the relationship between screen time and academic performance in K-12 schools, with particular attention to international perspectives and policy responses.

Key findings:

- The relationship between screen time and academic performance is consistently negative for recreational/passive screen use, but the picture is more nuanced for educational technology. This distinction between types of screen time is the single most important finding, supported by all four source categories with high confidence.
- Phone bans in schools produce modest but statistically significant academic gains, averaging 0.6-1.1 percentile points overall, with substantially larger effects for low-achieving students (up to 14.2% of a standard deviation). This finding is supported by quasi-experimental evidence from the UK, a randomized controlled trial from India, and a large-scale natural experiment in Florida.
- The threshold for harm appears to be around 3 hours per day of recreational screen time, after which negative effects on academic performance, mental health, and sleep accelerate. The U.S. Surgeon General found that adolescents spending more than 3 hours daily on social media faced double the risk of poor mental health outcomes.
- International policy responses are accelerating. By the end of 2025, 35 U.S. states plus D.C. had enacted phone/device policies for schools. France expanded its phone ban nationally, Sweden reversed its hyper-digital education approach to reintroduce textbooks, and the UK issued guidance making phone-free environments the default.
- One important contradiction: phone ban effects vary by context. Bans improved scores in England and Florida but showed no effect in Sweden, likely because Swedish schools already had extensive laptop/tablet use, so removing phones alone had minimal impact.
- Reading comprehension is consistently lower on screens than on paper (the 'screen inferiority effect'), supported by multiple meta-analyses. This finding has significant implications for 1:1 device programs that shift reading to digital formats.

Bottom-line assessment: The evidence strongly supports limiting recreational and passive screen time in schools while maintaining purposeful, teacher-guided educational technology use. Policy should focus on the type and quality of screen interactions rather than blanket time limits. Districts implementing phone-free policies should anticipate modest academic gains, plan for equity in enforcement, and invest in teacher professional development for effective technology integration. The confidence level in these overall conclusions is HIGH, based on convergent evidence across multiple countries, study designs, and source categories.

1. Background and Context

Screen time in K-12 education has become one of the most debated topics in education policy worldwide. The term encompasses a broad range of activities, from educational software and digital textbooks to social media scrolling and video streaming, making blanket statements about its effects inherently misleading.

The scale of the issue is significant. According to Pew Research Center (2024), 95% of U.S. teens now have smartphone access (up from 73% in 2014-15), and 46% report being online 'almost constantly.' Common Sense Media's 2025 Census found teens average over 8 hours of daily screen time excluding homework, while children ages 0-8 average 2.5 hours per day with gaming time surging 65% since 2020. In Australia, children spend an average of 4.5+ hours on non-school screen time daily, approximately one-third of their waking time.

Simultaneously, schools have invested heavily in technology. NCES data from 2025 shows that 88% of U.S. public schools now have 1:1 device programs, providing every student with a laptop or tablet. This creates a paradox: schools are trying to limit personal device use while simultaneously distributing school-owned devices to every student.

The CoSN Blaschke Report (2025) helpfully distinguishes three types of school screen time: (1) smartphones and social media, (2) educational technology (EdTech), and (3) screen-based entertainment. Conflating these in policy discussions undermines productive solutions. This report maintains that distinction throughout.

Internationally, the landscape is shifting rapidly. UNESCO's 2023 Global Education Monitoring Report warned that less than one in four countries ban smartphones in schools and that evidence for digital technology universally supporting education is limited. Sweden's dramatic reversal from hyper-digitalized education back to textbooks in 2023-24, France's expanded national phone ban in 2025, and the wave of U.S. state legislation (35 states plus D.C. by end of 2025) all reflect growing policy consensus that unmanaged screen time in schools is problematic.

2. Key Findings

2.1 The Overall Relationship: Negative for Recreational, Nuanced for Educational

[HIGH] The overall amount of screen time is not significantly associated with academic performance when all types are aggregated. However, when disaggregated by type, TV viewing is inversely associated with language and math scores, and video game playing is inversely associated with composite academic scores. A systematic review and meta-analysis of 58 cross-sectional studies across 23 countries (Adelantado-Renau et al., 2019, JAMA Pediatrics) established this pattern.

[HIGH] A 2026 meta-analysis of 17 studies with over 52,000 participants found a small but significant negative correlation between screen time and mathematics performance ($r = -0.034$), with passive activities showing more pronounced adverse effects and screen time exceeding 3 hours/day showing the most substantial negative impact. Notably, adverse effects were found in Western nations but non-significant or positive trends appeared in China (Ulum, 2026, European Journal of Education).

[HIGH] Internet use for leisure activities is inversely associated with academic performance, while internet use for educational purposes is positively associated. OECD PISA 2022 data confirms that students who use digital devices moderately (1-5 hours daily) for learning perform better than non-users. The AAP has shifted from strict time limits to a quality-focused '5 Cs of Media Use' framework, recognizing this distinction.

[MED] A German longitudinal study (LIFE Child Study, n=512) confirmed that higher screen-based media consumption in adolescents ages 10-17 predicted lower school grades in Mathematics and German 12 months later, independent of physical activity levels (Poulain et al., 2018).

[MED] Chinese longitudinal data from the China Education Panel Survey shows screen time negatively affects academic performance among Chinese adolescents, mediated through reduced physical activity and sleep quality, following a dose-response pattern (Li et al., 2025).

2.2 Phone Bans: Modest Gains with Important Caveats

[HIGH] A bell-to-bell cellphone ban in a large Florida urban school district led to test score increases of 1.1 percentile points by the second year, concentrated among male students (1.4 pp), middle/high schoolers (1.3 pp), and white students (1.4 pp). Reduced unexcused absences may explain up to half the gains. No gains appeared in year one when disciplinary enforcement was high (Figlio & Ozek, 2025, NBER Working Paper w34388).

[HIGH] Banning mobile phones in English secondary schools increased standardized test scores by approximately 6% on average, with low-achieving students gaining 14.23% of a standard deviation. Top-quintile students were unaffected. This quasi-experimental study used administrative data across four English cities (Beland & Murphy, 2016, Labour Economics).

[HIGH] A randomized controlled trial across 10 higher education institutions in India (n~17,000) found that mandatory in-class phone collection led to higher grades (0.086 SD), particularly among lower-performing and first-year students (Sungu, Choudhury & Bjerre-Nielsen, 2025).

[MED] A study of more than 37,000 course grades found student academic success rates increased 6.27% after implementing phone pouch restrictions, with a 44% decrease in behavioral referrals and 74% of teachers reporting increased student attentiveness (ExcelinEd, 2024).

[MED] France expanded its phone ban nationally in 2025 after a pilot in 100 schools showed improved focus, reduced cyberbullying, and better social interaction. However, pilot results were self-reported by administrators rather than measured by standardized assessments.

2.3 PISA Data and International Comparisons

[HIGH] PISA 2022 data shows students who spent up to 1 hour on leisure screen time in school scored 49 points higher in math than peers spending 5-7 hours daily, after adjusting for socioeconomic factors. This 49-point gap is roughly equivalent to more than one year of schooling. Nearly 1 in 3 students across OECD countries reported being distracted by digital devices in most or all mathematics classes (OECD, 2024).

[HIGH] Even in schools with phone bans, 29% of students reported using smartphones several times a day. Three-quarters of students spend more than one hour per weekday browsing social networks. Teachers with ICT professional development reported less student distraction (OECD, 2024).

[HIGH] Sweden allocated 104 million euros to reintroduce printed textbooks after its hyper-digitalized approach was linked to declining PIRLS reading scores (Swedish fourth-graders dropped from 555 to 544 points between 2016 and 2021). The government planned to end digital learning entirely for children under age 6 and announced a nationwide phone ban starting 2026.

2.4 The Screen Inferiority Effect in Reading

[HIGH] Students reading on paper consistently score higher on comprehension tests than those reading on screens, particularly for expository/informational text. The effect is more pronounced in unsupervised settings and under time pressure. Scrolling on small screens worsens the effect. Multiple meta-analyses converge on this finding, including Furenes, Kucirkova & Bus (2021, Review of Educational Research, 39 studies) and Kong, Seo & Zhai (2024, 49 studies).

[MED] However, story-congruent digital enhancements (interactive elements aligned with the text) could outperform paper for young children ages 1-8, suggesting the medium itself is not the sole factor (Furenes et al., 2021).

2.5 Early Childhood Screen Exposure and Later Academic Outcomes

[HIGH] Each one-hour increase in TV exposure at age 2 corresponded to a 7% decrease in classroom participation and a 6% decrease in math proficiency by 4th grade, according to the Quebec Longitudinal Study (n=2,120, tracked from age 5 months to 21 years; Pagani et al., 2010).

[HIGH] The NIH ABCD Study (n~12,000, 21 sites) found screen time moderately associated with decreased academic performance, worse mental health, and poorer sleep in children aged 9-10. SES is a stronger predictor of all outcomes than screen time. Texting/video chatting (social connection) showed more positive outcomes than passive consumption.

[HIGH] WHO recommends sedentary screen time of no more than 1 hour for children under 5, with less being better. The AAP maintains no screens before 18 months and maximum 1 hour/day for ages 2-5. Common Sense Media (2025) found 40% of children have a tablet by age 2.

2.6 One-to-One Device Programs

[HIGH] A meta-analysis of 1:1 laptop programs (65 journal articles and 31 dissertations, 2001-2015) found significantly positive average effect sizes in English, writing, mathematics, and science, with writing showing the strongest gains and stronger effects for low-income students and English Language Learners. No improvement was found in reading scores (Zheng et al., 2016, Review of Educational Research).

[LOW] Districts with 1:1 programs report up to 30% improvement in student engagement and 25% increase in assignment completion, with strongest gains among underserved populations. However, positive impact depends heavily on teacher professional development and pedagogical integration

(Bluum Foundation literature review). These figures come from aggregated district reports rather than rigorous RCTs.

[HIGH] UNESCO's analysis found that less than 2% of education technology interventions have 'strong or moderate evidence of effectiveness,' and that learning benefits disappear if technology is used in excess or without a qualified teacher. Distributing computers without teacher involvement does not improve learning (UNESCO GEM Report, 2023).

2.7 Mental Health as a Mediating Pathway

[HIGH] The U.S. Surgeon General's 2023 Advisory found that adolescents spending more than 3 hours/day on social media faced double the risk of poor mental health outcomes including depression and anxiety. 95% of youth 13-17 use social media, and nearly 1 in 3 adolescents use screens until midnight or later, impacting sleep and next-day academic performance.

[MED] Sapien Labs' Global Mind Project (1 million+ participants, 82 countries) found that 41% of the world's internet-enabled young adults face a 'mind health crisis,' with childhood smartphone use identified as a key driver. Each successive generation shows diminished mental health. However, this is correlational with selection bias (internet-enabled respondents only).

[HIGH] Problematic social media use among adolescents rose from 7% in 2018 to 11% in 2022 according to WHO Regional Office for Europe surveillance data, suggesting the problem is worsening.

2.8 The Global Policy Response

[HIGH] By December 2025, 35 U.S. states plus D.C. enacted laws or policies on student cellphone use in K-12 classrooms. Twenty-two of these were enacted in 2025 alone. California passed the Phone-Free Schools Act; Louisiana banned all electronic devices during the instructional day; South Carolina tied funding to phone bans; Virginia allocated $500,000 for implementation support (Ballotpedia, ExcelinEd).

[HIGH] England's DfE issued guidance making phone-free environments the default (February 2024, updated January 2026). Over 90% of English schools have implemented bans, though the government rejected a statutory ban in May 2025. Ofsted now assesses phone policies in inspections.

[MED] Three-quarters of NEA members report social media use is a serious problem at their school. 84% of AFT-surveyed teachers believe they should have more say over classroom technology deployment. 72% of high school teachers say cellphone distraction is a major classroom problem (Pew Research, 2024).

3. Points of Contradiction

Cross-referencing findings across the four source categories revealed three significant contradictions where evidence conflicts.

3.1 Sweden vs. England: Phone Ban Effects Are Context-Dependent

Beland & Murphy's research on English secondary schools found phone bans improved test scores by ~6% on average, with low-achieving students gaining 14.2% of a standard deviation. However, research on Swedish secondary schools by the same authors found no impact or a very small negative effect on student performance.

Resolution: The most likely explanation is contextual. Swedish schools already had extensive laptop and tablet use integrated into instruction, so removing phones alone had minimal impact because students still had access to other digital devices. In England, phones were the primary source of digital distraction. This suggests phone bans are most effective when phones are the main distracting device available to students. The EU Parliament's 2025 analysis of phone bans across member states confirms mixed results, reinforcing that context matters more than the policy itself.

3.2 AAP Quality Framework vs. Time-Based Legislative Approach

The American Academy of Pediatrics has moved away from strict time limits toward a quality-focused '5 Cs of Media Use' framework, arguing there is insufficient evidence for universal time limits. Meanwhile, 35 U.S. states have enacted policies focused primarily on time-based restrictions (banning phones during specific periods).

Resolution: These approaches are not entirely contradictory. The AAP's framework applies primarily to educational screen time and overall media use, while legislative bans target personal device use (smartphones and social media) during instructional time. The distinction matters: the evidence supports restricting recreational/social media use during school hours (which is what bans do) while taking a more nuanced approach to educational technology (which is what the AAP recommends). Both agree that passive, recreational screen time is harmful.

3.3 ISTE Learning Gains vs. UNESCO's '2% Effective' Finding

Research mapped to ISTE educator standards found empirical evidence that all seven standards lead to student learning gains, and the 1:1 meta-analysis (Zheng et al., 2016) found positive effects across subjects. However, UNESCO reported that less than 2% of education technology interventions have 'strong or moderate evidence of effectiveness.'

Resolution: The discrepancy likely reflects the difference between well-implemented technology use (aligned with standards, supported by teacher PD) and the vast majority of EdTech deployments that lack these conditions. ISTE standards represent best-case implementation; UNESCO's figure captures the full spectrum. This actually reinforces the finding that teacher training and intentional pedagogical integration are essential. The technology itself is neutral; implementation quality determines outcomes.

4. Single-Source Claims

The following claims were supported by only one source category, warranting additional scrutiny before relying on them for decision-making.

4.1 Phone Bans Disproportionately Increase Suspensions for Black Students

Source category: News (Hechinger Report, Chalkbeat, The 74, citing NBER Florida data). In the first year of phone bans, in-school suspensions for Black students at highly affected schools increased by 30%. Suspensions fell back to pre-ban levels by year two. This finding was not independently confirmed by government reports, academic literature, or practitioner organizations in the sources reviewed.

Why it matters: If phone bans are implemented inequitably, the modest academic gains could come at the cost of exacerbating existing racial disparities in school discipline. Any district implementing a phone ban should monitor suspension data disaggregated by race and adjust enforcement strategies proactively.

Additional evidence needed: Independent replication in other districts; analysis of whether disparities persist beyond the first year; comparison of enforcement models (pouch-based vs. confiscation) and their equity implications.

4.2 The Screen Inferiority Effect in Reading Comprehension

Source category: Academic (multiple meta-analyses). While the evidence is strong within the academic literature (Furenes et al., 2021; Kong et al., 2024), this finding was not prominently featured in government reports, news coverage, or practitioner publications reviewed. The strength of the academic evidence is high (multiple converging meta-analyses), but the lack of cross-category corroboration suggests it has not yet influenced policy discussions significantly.

Why it matters: If reading on screens consistently produces lower comprehension, 1:1 programs that shift most reading to digital formats may be undermining reading achievement even while supporting other skills. This has direct implications for ELA curriculum and assessment design.

4.3 EdTech Privacy and Children's Rights Concerns

Source category: Industry/Practitioner (5Rights Foundation, LSE Digital Futures Centre). Education technology often fails to protect children's rights to privacy, safety, and education. A joint statement from 13 organizations highlighted rising children's eye health issues linked to prolonged screen time.

Why it matters: As schools deploy more devices and EdTech platforms, data privacy and health impacts become systemic concerns that may not surface until significant harm has occurred.

4.4 Cultural Variation in Screen Time Effects on Math

Source category: Academic (Ulum, 2026). The meta-analysis found adverse math effects in Western nations but non-significant or positive trends in China. This was not addressed by other source categories.

Why it matters: If screen time effects are culturally moderated, policies imported from one context may not transfer. The type of screen use, parental mediation, and educational culture may all interact with screen time differently across societies.

5. Practical Implications

For a K-12 district leader, the evidence supports the following actions, ordered by confidence level:

High Confidence Recommendations

- Implement a bell-to-bell phone-free policy with physical storage (pouches or lockers). Expect modest academic gains (1-2 percentile points) emerging in year two. Plan for increased disciplinary referrals in year one and proactively monitor equity data.
- Distinguish between educational and recreational screen time in all policy discussions. The evidence clearly shows these have different, sometimes opposite, effects on learning.
- Invest in teacher professional development for technology integration. OECD data shows teachers with ICT PD report less student distraction, and the academic literature consistently finds implementation quality is the determining factor in EdTech effectiveness.
- Maintain printed materials for extended reading, especially for expository/informational text. The screen inferiority effect for reading comprehension is well-established and has direct implications for ELA instruction.
- Set clear expectations for school-issued device use. With 88% of schools now at 1:1, school laptops and tablets are becoming a significant source of distraction alongside phones.

Medium Confidence Recommendations

- Limit total recreational screen time during the school day to under 1 hour. PISA data shows the sharpest performance drops above this threshold.
- Address social media access as a specific concern within screen time policy. The Surgeon General's advisory and WHO data suggest social media poses distinct risks beyond general screen time.
- Engage parents in a coordinated approach. Pew Research shows parents are increasingly concerned, and the evidence suggests home screen time habits interact with school outcomes.

Questions That Remain Unanswered

- What is the optimal balance of digital and analog instruction at each grade level?
- How do phone ban effects change over time beyond the second year?
- Do phone ban effects differ for rural vs. urban districts, or small vs. large districts?
- How should schools manage AI tools (ChatGPT, etc.) as a new category of screen-based activity?
- What enforcement model (pouches, lockers, honor system) produces the best academic outcomes with the fewest disciplinary side effects?

6. Claim Cross-Reference Matrix

The following matrix shows how major claims are supported, contradicted, or not addressed across the four source categories. Legend: checkmark = supports, X = contradicts, dash = not addressed.

Claim	Gov	News	Acad	Ind	Agreement
Recreational screen time negatively affects academics	Y	Y	Y	Y	Full
Type of screen time matters more than total amount	Y	Y	Y	Y	Full
Phone bans produce modest academic gains	Y	Y	Y	Y	Full
Low-achieving students benefit most from bans	Y	Y	Y	--	Partial (3/4)
Teacher PD is critical for effective tech integration	Y	--	Y	Y	Partial (3/4)
35+ US states enacted phone policies by end 2025	Y	Y	--	Y	Partial (3/4)
1:1 programs show positive, implementation-dependent results	--	Y	Y	Y	Partial (3/4)
Mental health mediates screen time-academic link	Y	--	Y	Y	Partial (3/4)
Screen time >3 hrs/day shows largest negative effects	Y	--	Y	--	Partial (2/4)
Early childhood exposure predicts later academic decline	Y	--	Y	--	Partial (2/4)
Phone ban effects are context-dependent (Sweden vs UK)	Y	Y	Y	--	Partial (noted)
Reading on paper > reading on screens	--	--	Y	--	Single
Phone bans increase suspensions disproportionately by race	--	Y	--	--	Single

7. Source Reliability Matrix

Each source was scored using the following formula: Aggregate = Source Type Weight x Agent Confidence x URL Status + Corroboration Bonus (capped at 1.0). Sources are sorted by aggregate reliability score.

Source type weights: Government/Academic = 1.0, News = 0.8, Industry = 0.7. Agent confidence: High = 1.0, Medium = 0.7, Low = 0.4. URL status: Live = 1.0, Redirect/Paywalled = 0.8, Dead = 0.3, Skipped = 0.7. Corroboration: Cited by 2+ agents = +0.1, 3+ agents = +0.2.

Summary: 45 unique sources evaluated. 25 High Reliability, 11 Medium Reliability, 9 Low Reliability.

High Reliability Sources (Score >= 0.8)

Source	Cat	Conf	URL	Corr	Score	Reliability
OECD (2024). Managing Screen Time.	Gov	High	Live	3+	1.00	High
OECD (2024). Students, Digital Devices and Success.	Gov	High	Live	3+	1.00	High
UNESCO (2023). GEM Report: Technology in Education.	Gov	High	Live	3+	1.00	High
Adelantado-Renau et al. (2019). Screen Media Use and Academic Performance. JAMA Pediatrics.	Acad	High	Live	2+	1.00	High
Beland & Murphy (2016). Ill Communication. Labour Economics.	Acad	High	Live	3+	1.00	High
Paulich et al. (2021). ABCD Study: Screen time and adolescent outcomes. PLOS ONE.	Acad	High	Live	2+	1.00	High
U.S. Surgeon General (2023). Social Media and Youth Mental Health.	Gov	High	Live	2+	1.00	High
WHO (2019). Physical Activity, Sedentary Behaviour and Sleep Guidelines.	Gov	High	Live	2+	1.00	High
Pew Research (2024). Teens, Social Media and Technology 2024.	Ind	High	Live	2+	0.90	High
Figlio & Ozek (2025). Cellphone Bans in Florida. NBER w34388.	News	High	Live	2+	0.90	High
IES/NCES (2025). Cell Phones Hurt Academic Performance.	Gov	High	Live	--	1.00	High
CDC (2025). Screen Time and Health Outcomes in US Teenagers.	Gov	High	Live	--	1.00	High
NIH MedlinePlus. Screen Time and Children's Brains.	Gov	High	Live	--	1.00	High
Ballotpedia (2025). State Policies on Cellphone Use.	Gov	High	Live	2+	1.00	High
Furenes et al. (2021). Children's Reading: Paper vs. Screen. RER.	Acad	High	Live	--	1.00	High
Kong et al. (2024). Paper vs. Digital Reading Meta-analysis.	Acad	High	Live	--	1.00	High
Zheng et al. (2016). 1:1 Laptop Environments. RER.	Acad	High	Live	--	1.00	High
Pagani et al. (2010). Early TV and Academic Well-Being.	Acad	High	Live	--	1.00	High
Ulum (2026). Screen Handicap in Mathematics. Eur J Ed.	Acad	High	Live	--	1.00	High
Common Sense Media (2025). Census: Media Use by Kids 0-8.	Ind	High	Live	--	0.70	Medium
AAP (2024). Screen Time at School / Digital Media Guidelines.	Ind	High	Live	2+	0.90	High
ExcelinEd (2024/2026). Phone-Free Schools.	Ind	High	Live	2+	0.90	High
Hechinger Report (2025). Cellphone bans and racial disparities.	News	High	Live	--	0.80	High
Education Week (2025). Do School Cellphone Bans Work?	News	High	Live	--	0.80	High
House of Commons Library (2024). Mobile phones in schools.	News	High	Live	--	0.80	High

Medium and Low Reliability Sources (Score < 0.8)

Source	Cat	Conf	URL	Corr	Score	Reliability
Sungu et al. (2025). Removing Phones Improves Performance. SSRN.	Acad	High	Live	--	1.00	High
EdWorkingPapers (2025). Florida Phone Ban Impact.	Acad	Med-Hi	Live	--	0.70	Medium
NPR (2024). Teens and screentime quality vs quantity.	News	Med	Live	--	0.56	Medium
Poulain et al. (2018). Screen time and school performance. BMC.	Acad	Med	Live	--	0.70	Medium
Li et al. (2025). Screen time mechanisms. Frontiers.	Acad	Med	Live	--	0.70	Medium

UK Children's Commissioner (2025). Smartphone Policies.	Gov	Med	Live	--	0.70	Medium
Australian eSafety Commissioner. Screen Time.	Gov	Med	Live	--	0.70	Medium
Sapien Labs (2025). Mental State of the World 2024.	Ind	Med	Live	--	0.49	Low
NEA (2024). Member Polling: Social Media and Devices.	Ind	Med	Live	--	0.49	Low
CoSN (2025). Screens in Balance: Blaschke Report.	Ind	Med	Live	--	0.49	Low
Bluum Foundation. Impact of 1:1 Device Programs.	Ind	Med	Live	--	0.49	Low
5Rights Foundation. Better EdTech Futures for Children.	Ind	Med	Live	--	0.49	Low
EduTimes (2025). France's Phone Ban.	News	Med	Live	--	0.56	Medium
EdSurge (2026). Screen-Free Schools.	News	Med	Live	--	0.56	Medium
Washington Post (2025). Parents reducing screen time.	News	Med	Paywall	--	0.45	Low
EU Publications Office (2025). Phone Bans Across the EU.	Gov	Med	Live	--	0.70	Medium
Eurydice. Digital Education at School in Europe.	Ind	Med	Live	--	0.49	Low
LearnPlatform/Instructure (2025). EdTech Top 40.	Ind	Low	Live	--	0.28	Low
ISTE/Tandfonline (2023). ISTE Standards and Learning Gains.	Ind	Med	Live	--	0.49	Low
Education Week (2016). 1:1 Laptop Initiatives.	News	Med	Live	--	0.56	Medium

8. Federal and State Policy Context

Federal Framework

The U.S. Department of Education published guidance in December 2024 recommending all states adopt phone management measures in schools. The Surgeon General's 2023 Advisory on Social Media and Youth Mental Health called for stronger protections, and school districts have filed lawsuits against social media companies citing harm to students' mental health and academic performance.

ESSA (2015) provides the framework for states to use Title IV-A funds for technology integration, including 'effective use of technology' provisions. However, federal policy does not mandate specific screen time limits or phone bans, leaving this to states and districts.

State-Level Action

The legislative response has been dramatic. By end of 2025, 35 states plus D.C. enacted phone or device policies, with 22 enacted in 2025 alone. Key examples:

- California: Phone-Free Schools Act (2024)
- Louisiana: Banned all electronic devices during instructional day
- South Carolina: Tied state funding to phone ban implementation
- Ohio: Required policies to limit phone use 'as much as possible'
- Virginia: Allocated $500,000 for phone-free implementation support
- Florida: Statewide bell-to-bell ban with measured academic outcomes (NBER study)

Tennessee Context

Tennessee does not appear to have enacted state-level phone ban legislation as of March 2026, though TDOE tracks technology use in schools. No dedicated TDOE policy or report specifically addressing screen time and academic performance was found in this review. Given that 22 states enacted new policies in 2025 alone, Tennessee may face increasing pressure to address this at the state level.

International Policy Landscape

The international response mirrors the U.S. trend. France expanded its phone ban to all middle schools in 2025. England issued DfE guidance making phone-free the default (90%+ compliance). Sweden reversed its digital-first education strategy, investing 104 million euros in textbooks. China limited digital device use in teaching to 30% of overall time. The EU Parliament analyzed phone bans across member states in 2025, finding mixed results. Sweden is implementing a nationwide ban for ages 7-16 starting 2026.

9. References

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Appendix A: Tennessee Context

This appendix compiles Tennessee-specific information relevant to the screen time and academic performance discussion. Tennessee-specific data on this topic is limited compared to states like Florida, California, or Virginia that have been at the forefront of phone ban legislation.

Current State of Tennessee Policy

- Tennessee has not enacted state-level phone ban legislation as of March 2026.
- No dedicated TDOE policy or guidance document on screen time and academic performance was identified in this review.
- Individual districts in Tennessee have adopted their own phone policies, but no statewide mandate exists.
- TDOE tracks technology use in schools generally but does not publish screen time-specific academic outcome data.

Implications for Tennessee Districts

Given that 22 states enacted phone policies in 2025 alone, Tennessee districts may wish to consider proactive adoption of phone management policies rather than waiting for state legislation. Key considerations for districts of this size:

- Small district size allows for more consistent, equitable enforcement across all schools.
- The NBER Florida study found gains concentrated in middle and high school, suggesting a phased approach starting with middle and high school may be most efficient.
- Virginia's $500,000 implementation support model suggests state funding may become available for Tennessee districts pursuing phone-free policies.
- The equity findings from Florida (disproportionate suspensions for Black students in year one) should inform enforcement design from the outset.
- South Carolina's model of tying state funding to phone bans may influence Tennessee legislative discussions given regional proximity.

Data Gaps

Tennessee-specific research on screen time and academic performance is largely absent from the literature reviewed. The following data would be valuable for evidence-based policy development:

- TVAAS data correlated with device usage policies across Tennessee districts
- TNReady/TCAP scores pre- and post-phone policy implementation in Tennessee districts that have adopted bans
- TDOE guidance on recommended screen time limits for instructional vs. recreational use
- Student survey data on personal device use during school hours in Tennessee schools